

WEEK 6

Iterations

WEEK 6

06

ECHO · 01

UQ Board Game



Digital board-game prototype — Great Court, St Lucia campus.

WHAT IS IT?

A team-based campus scavenger hunt where students follow clues to uncover hidden locations, historical events and artefacts. Completing challenges unlocks pieces of UQ's history, while teams can trade duplicates and compete to complete their collection.

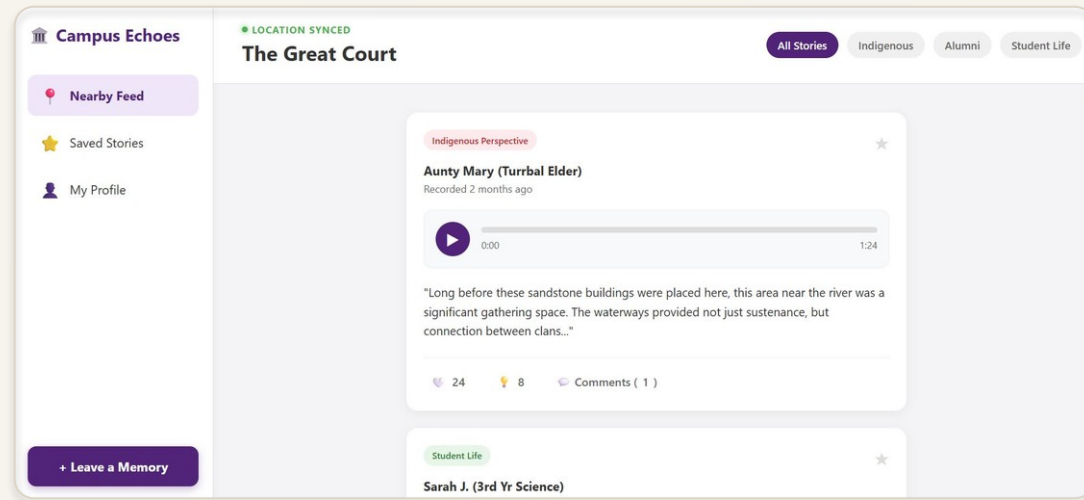
WHY (RESEARCH)?

- **Interactive exploration is more engaging** → Participants preferred interactive experiences; research supports active, place-based learning.
- **Campus history can build belonging** → Research links knowledge of place and institutional history with stronger connection and belonging.
- **Physical movement can make history meaningful** → Research on historical trails supports learning through walking and discovering stories in real places.

TEST RESULTS

- **Game purpose was clear, but learning depth was uncertain** → Some felt simple trivia **would not lead to meaningful learning**.
- **Time was a major barrier** → Participants repeatedly said they might skip it if it was **too long or tedious**.
- **The game risked feeling forced** → "Assigned fun" or overly complicated gameplay could discourage participation.
- **Engagement needed stronger incentives** → Suggestions included **points, leaderboards and small rewards** to encourage participation.

UQ Stories



Low-fidelity web prototype — Campus Echoes story feed.

Prototype → https://github.com/Inseo-Park/DECO3500_Inshallah-and-Vibes/blob/main/Low%20Fidelity%20Prototypes/Ishan/uq_stories.html

WHAT IS IT?

- Interactive web platform for exploring campus history.
- Uncovers hidden histories and lived experiences connected to specific campus locations.
- Features short, bite-sized stories instead of static plaques or fact sheets.
- Stories are shared by students, alumni, staff, and Indigenous elders.
- Allows users to discover stories where the events actually took place.
- Creates a more personal, engaging, and location-based way to experience campus history.

WHY?

- **History is stronger in context** – Connecting stories to the places where they happened can make history feel more relevant.
- **People connect with people** – Lived experiences and personal stories can humanise institutional history.
- **Campus is more than its buildings** – Local history can strengthen students' sense of place and connection to their university.
- **Not every story makes it into the archive** – Community and oral histories can surface perspectives overlooked by traditional historical narratives.

TEST RESULTS

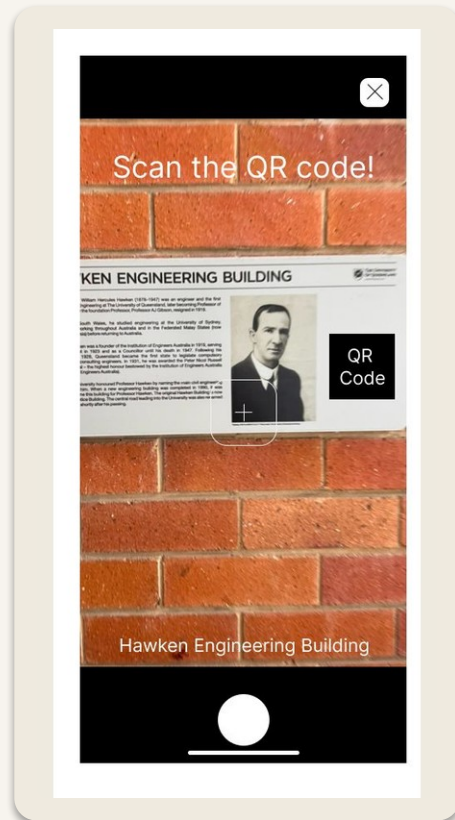
"The website was very intuitive to use."

"Learning about their history and the experiences of past students made these locations feel more meaningful."

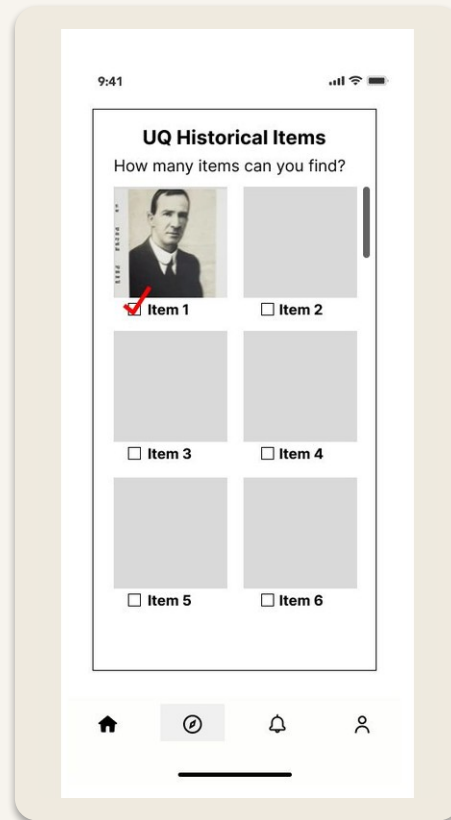
"The more people who engage with the platform, the more likely I am to check or post my own memory."

"A suggestion for future improvements could be to add an interactive map to further explore the campus."

Scavenger Hunt



Scan the QR code on a building plaque.



Collect UQ historical items in-app.

WHAT IS IT?

- A team-based campus scavenger hunt.
- Students follow clues to uncover hidden locations, historical events and artefacts.
- Completing challenges to unlock pieces of UQ's history.
- Teams can trade duplicates.
- Compete to complete their collection.

WHY?

- **Place-Based & Embodied Learning** → Physically navigating campus to find historical markers increases spatial recall, campus belonging, and contextual retention compared to passive learning.
- **Active Discovery (Inquiry-Based Learning)** → Clue-solving triggers intrinsic motivation and active problem-solving, improving engagement with institutional history over rote memorization.
- **Social Interdependence & Collaboration** → Team-based mechanics and inter-team trading foster communication, peer negotiation, and social bonding (cooperative learning theory).
- **Gamification & Self-Determination** → Collectible progression (unlocking history, completing sets) satisfies psychological needs for competence and autonomy, driving task completion.

TEST RESULTS

- The participants preferred the function that capturing the QR code on description board and showing each information.

Story Pods: Listen and Share Stories



1 Approach & Notice

A student walks through the Library Courtyard and notices the Listening Pod – a quiet, inviting space.



2 Step In & Settle

She steps inside and sits down. The pod senses her presence and the soft interior lighting gently activates.



3 Listen

A story, secret, or memory begins to play in 360° audio. She listens, immersed in the moment.



4 Respond

Inspired, she presses the mic button to leave her own voice memory or thought.

WHAT IS IT?

- A quiet, semi-private **listening and sharing** space placed within the campus landscape.
- Students discover stories, memories and historical moments connected to UQ.
- Audio, video and interactive prompts encourage exploration.
- Students can leave their own Echo for someone else to discover.
- The space activates when someone approaches.

WHY?

- Students often experience campus between classes, during breaks or while alone.
- Existing campus history is not always encountered naturally.
- A low-pressure installation can encourage curiosity and place attachment.
- Sharing stories creates an asynchronous connection between students.
- The design balances privacy with connection to the surrounding environment.

TEST RESULTS

- Students preferred a smaller, understated structure that maintained visibility of the surroundings.
- The combination of audio and visuals made historical stories more engaging.
- Participants responded positively to the idea of discovering something left by another student.
- Some users felt a large enclosed pod could be intimidating.
- **Design change:** Explore a smaller, open-sided form with clear interaction cues and optional privacy.

WEEK 7

Selection of Final Idea

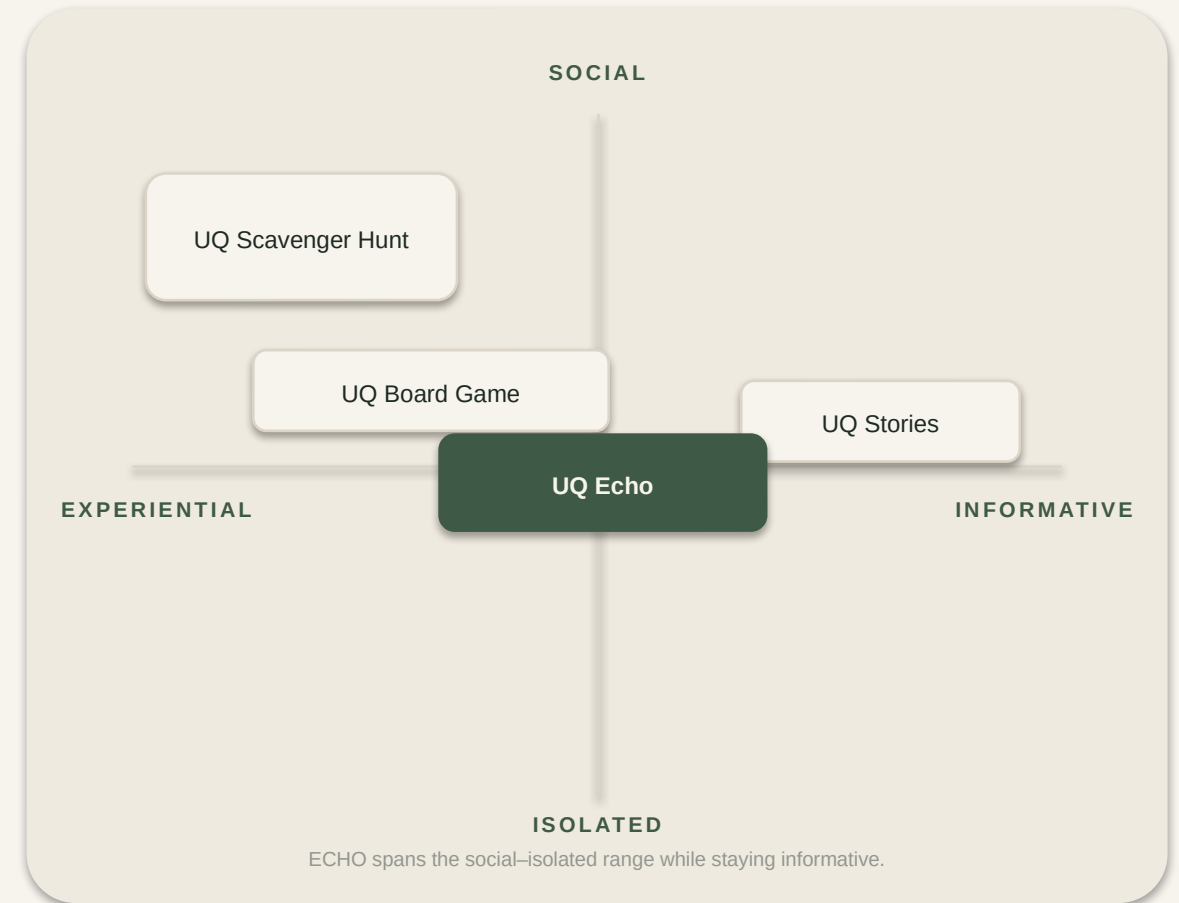
WEEK 7

07

ECHO · 06

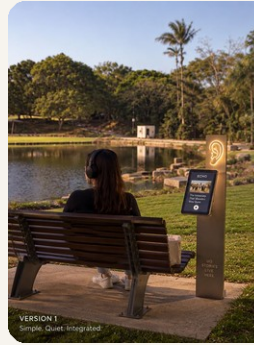
How did we arrive at this idea

- **Flexible engagement** — students choose how they participate: quietly listening alone, or leaving their own Echo as an asynchronous social act for someone else to find
- **No team or scheduling required** — unlike UQ Quest (needs a team) or the board game (needs multiple players at once), Echo works for a single student at any moment
- **Same historical depth as Stories of UQ** — delivers the same grounding in UQ's history and memory, but isn't limited to one-directional, passive listening
- **Low-pressure and inclusive** — suits introverted or time-poor students who wouldn't engage with a competitive or scheduled format
- **Builds social value over time** — each Echo left behind adds to a growing, shared archive of the campus, so the experience becomes more social and meaningful the more people use it
- **Most versatile positioning** — spans both the social and isolated range while staying informative, giving it broader appeal than concepts fixed to a single mode



Echo

ECHO is an interactive storytelling experience that allows students to discover UQ's history, memories and student experiences, while leaving something behind for others to find.



Concept renders — ECHO installed in existing campus seating and lakeside spaces.

ASSUMPTIONS

- Students may engage more when they can choose how and when to participate.
- Short, accessible stories may suit students with limited time.
- Personal contributions can create a sense of connection between students.
- A physical installation may encourage curiosity and place-based discovery.

EVIDENCES

- **Interest in UQ history:** Students are curious about campus stories.
- **Familiar campus spaces:** Students regularly revisit preferred locations.
- **Existing downtime:** Students relax, study and socialise between classes.
- **Seamless integration:** Place ECHO where students already spend time.

WHAT DO WE HAVE TO TEST?

- Will students stop and interact with ECHO during their free time?
- Do students prefer audio, video or short text-based stories?
- Does the option to leave an Echo encourage participation?
- Which physical form feels most approachable: a shared space or an individual installation?
- Can the experience communicate UQ's history while remaining engaging and accessible?

WEEK 8

Selection of Final Idea

WEEK 8

08

ECHO · 09

Proof of Concept

PARTICIPANTS: GROUPS + INDIVIDUAL EXPERIENCES



MOST PREFERRED EXPERIENCE



WHAT WE WANTED TO FIND

- App usability and navigation.
- Interest in UQ stories.
- Preferred content formats.
- Explore stories independently.
- Choose audio, video or text.
- Connect stories to UQ.
- Decide whether to leave an Echo.

USER GOALS

- Explore stories independently.
- Choose audio, video or text.
- Connect stories to UQ.
- Decide whether to leave an Echo.
- Experience short, accessible content.
- Discover something meaningful.
- Interact comfortably in public.
- Engage during existing downtime.

What participants told us

Four participant interviews · selected quotes from the user-testing sessions

01 ENGAGEMENT & CURIOSITY

"I probably wouldn't have taken the initiative myself. But once we were watching, I was interested."

"I was curious. I was definitely curious."

"We didn't know a lot about the history, and this video made it more accessible."

"If there was something at the direct area where something happened... I would be interested to learn the history of that."

"I like the aspect of leaving something to the next person."

02 FORMAT & ACCESSIBILITY

"Honestly, I would not listen to it, but I would read it."

"Select text more than audios and videos."

"I need subtitles to engage with a video."

"I like both because if there's both, then there's subtitles."

"I liked the film. I'm a visual learner."

"It'd be nice if... I could hook up my phone to play, so you don't have to do it in front of everyone."

03 APPROACHABILITY & PLACE

"The picture looks beautiful, and the book looks great."

"I feel like if the screen was static, it would work... with the writing of the event."

"I like the setup... with a roof."

"I'd be a little bit embarrassed to sit at C... A makes it a bit goofy."

"This feels like I'm more just nonchalant... [the other one] is... a little scary."

"My favourite spot... would be Great Court... I feel very safe... there's food, there's coffee."

DESIGN INDICATION

Testing suggests that ECHO should be brief, optional and low-pressure; offer text, subtitles and media choice; connect stories to specific places; and support private participation.

Testing Results

WHAT WE DISCOVERED

- **Engagement varied:** Some explored briefly; others engaged longer.
- **Format preferences differed:** Participants preferred different media formats.
- **Physical form mattered:** Smaller, approachable installations felt more comfortable.
- **Location created interest:** Place-based stories encouraged exploration.

EXPERIENCES PEOPLE WANTED

- Short, accessible stories.
- Choice of audio, video and text. With subtitles.
- Location-based content.
- Integration with existing seating.
- Comfortable, low-pressure interaction.
- Does not attract attention (low-key).

KEY DESIGN CHANGE

Large listening pod → Smaller, adaptable ECHO installation integrated into campus spaces.

From People to Design

Real conversations. Meaningful insights.
A stronger ECHO.

1. PLACE

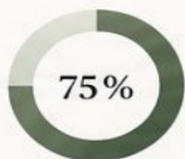
Students have familiar spaces and are curious about UQ's history.



"Put it where students already are."

"I often hang around the Great Court... it's just a good spot to meet and relax."

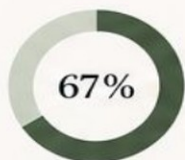
— Participant



of participants mentioned specific campus locations they regularly visit (e.g. Great Court, grass areas, basketball court).

"Being here, I kind of liked how significant UQ has been politically in Queensland and Australia."

— Participant



showed interest in learning more about UQ's history and past student experiences.



INSIGHT

Students are curious about UQ's history and already spend time in specific campus locations.



DESIGN DECISION

Place ECHO in existing, well-used spaces so it fits naturally into students' routines and sparks curiosity through place-based stories.

Great Court

Terraces

Lakeside

2. CONTENT & TIME

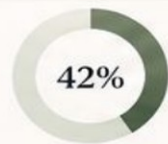
Students have different preferences and varying levels of time.



"Make it easy to engage, but reward curiosity."

"Honestly, probably once. I'll do it once and then forget about it."

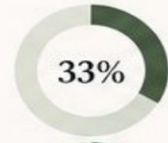
— Participant 1



preferred short, quick interactions (under 2 minutes).

"I would not listen to it, but I would read it."

— Participant 2



preferred reading text over audio or video.

"I liked the video, but subtitles would help."

— Participant 3



preferred video or audio (with subtitles).



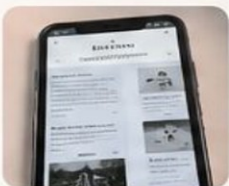
INSIGHT

Engagement levels and content preferences vary — a single format or long experience may lose interest.



DESIGN DECISION

Provide multiple formats (text, audio, video) with a short entry point and optional deeper content.



Read



Watch



Listen

3. PHYSICAL EXPERIENCE

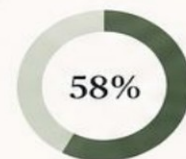


The form and setting influence whether students feel comfortable interacting.

"Accessible, subtle and inviting."

"I feel like I'd be a little bit embarrassed to sit at the big one."

— Participant 1



preferred a smaller, understated installation over a large, central one.

"A smaller book beside a bench feels more approachable."

— Participant 2



said privacy or optional privacy would make them more likely to interact.



INSIGHT

A large, highly visible installation can feel intimidating. Students prefer smaller, more discreet forms.



DESIGN DECISION

Develop a smaller, book-like installation that integrates with existing seating, with optional privacy elements.

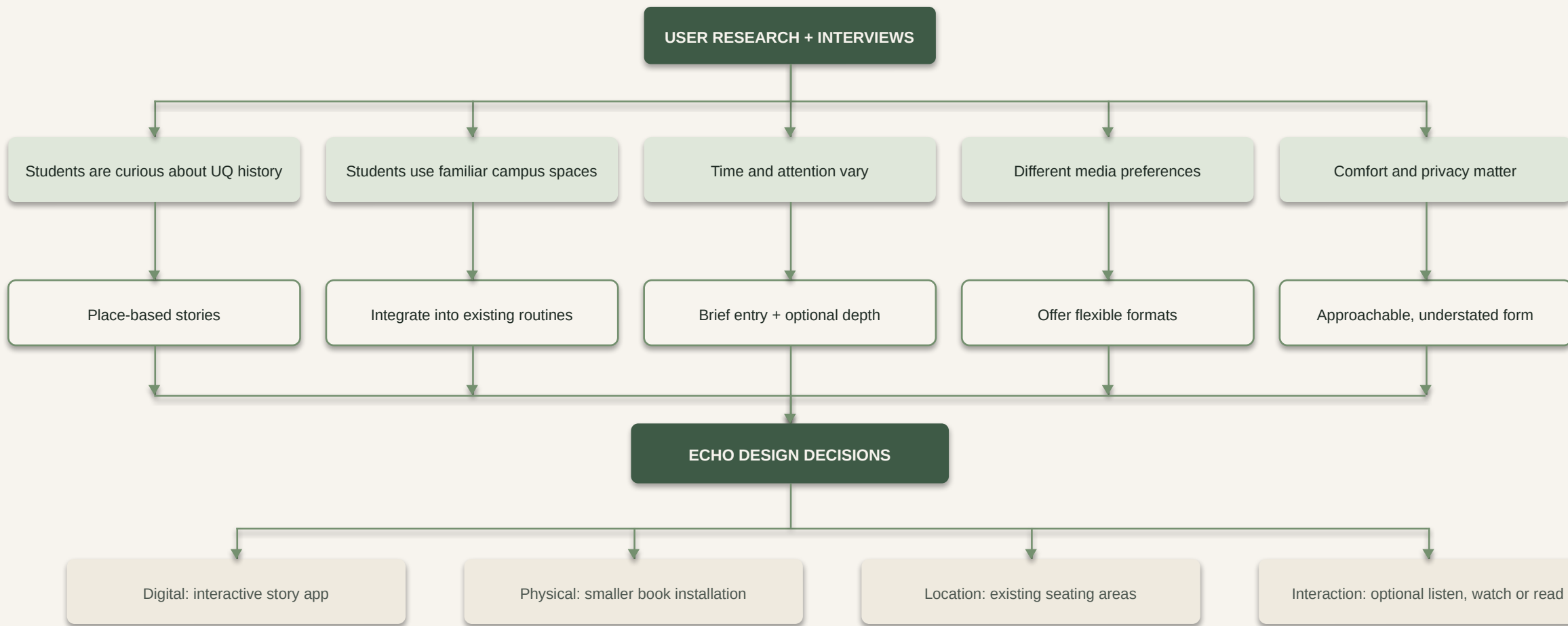


Large, central installation can feel intimidating.



Smaller, integrated installation feels approachable.

From research to design decisions

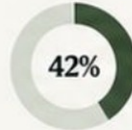
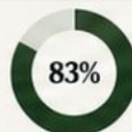


From Insights to Design Decisions

How student voices shaped ECHO

ECHO

Different voices.
A shared place.

THEME	EVIDENCE (QUOTES & DATA)		INSIGHT	DESIGN DECISION	
 INTEREST IN UQ HISTORY Students are curious about campus stories.	<i>"Being here, I kind of liked how significant UQ has been politically in Queensland and Australia."</i> — Participant	 67% showed interest in learning about UQ's history.	History feels meaningful when it's personal and place-based.	 Create engaging, location-based stories through ECHO.	
 FAMILIAR CAMPUS SPACES Students revisit specific locations.	<i>"I often hang around the Great Court... it's just a good spot to meet and relax."</i> — Participant	 75% mentioned specific campus locations (e.g. Great Court, terraces, grass areas).	Students already have places they spend time in.	 Place ECHO in existing, well-used spaces.	
 TIME & ATTENTION Engagement levels vary.	<i>"Honestly, probably once. I'll do it once and then forget about it."</i> — Participant	 42% preferred short, quick interactions (under 2 minutes).	Not everyone will engage deeply, so the experience needs to be accessible and optional.	 Design for a quick entry point with option for deeper exploration.	
 CONTENT PREFERENCES Different formats appeal to different students.	<i>"I would not listen to it, but I would read it."</i> — Participant	<i>"I liked the video, but subtitles would help."</i> — Participant	 33% preferred reading text over audio or video.	A single format may exclude some users.	 Offer multiple formats (text, audio, video) with subtitles or transcripts.
 COMFORT & PRIVACY The physical form affects willingness to interact.	<i>"I feel like I'd be a little bit embarrassed to sit at the big one."</i> — Participant	 58% preferred a smaller, more understated installation.	Large, highly visible installations can feel intimidating.	 Develop a smaller, book-like installation with optional privacy.	
 PLACE-BASED STORIES Location adds relevance.	<i>"If there was something like that at this area... I would be interested to learn the history of that."</i> — Participant	 83% said location-based stories would make them more likely to engage.	Stories connected to specific places feel more relevant and engaging.	 Use location-specific Echoes and install in meaningful campus spaces.	

KEY FINDING

Students are open to exploring UQ's history when it fits into their everyday campus life.



FINAL DESIGN DIRECTION

ECHO combines a location-based digital experience with a physical installation that is accessible, optional and integrated into existing student spaces.



In familiar campus spaces



Multiple content formats



Short or deep interactions

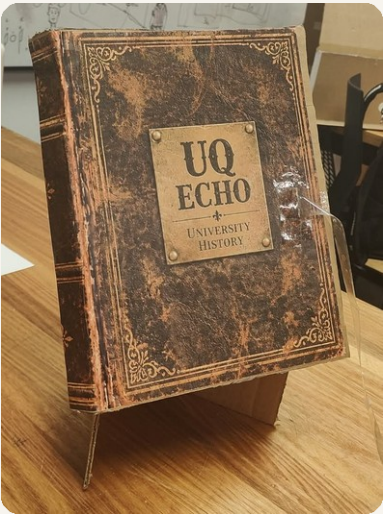


A welcoming, understated form



"Small moments can create a big sense of belonging."

Testing the book installation



WHAT WE TESTED

A low-fidelity cardboard book with printed covers, a tablet running the ECHO interface, and Wizard-of-Oz facilitation — to see how people approach, open and use the physical installation.

Pictured: the open book and tablet, the printed cover, and a participant testing on campus.

EVIDENCE · WHAT PARTICIPANTS SAID

WHAT WE TOOK FROM IT

ACCESSIBILITY & LANGUAGE

“I need subtitles to engage with a video.”
— Participant

→ Some people rely on written text to follow spoken content.

MEDIA PREFERENCES

“Honestly, I would not listen to it, but I would read it.”
— Participant

→ No single format suits everyone.

PLACE & CURIOSITY

“If there was something at the direct area where something happened... I would be interested to learn the history of that.”
— Participant

→ Stories tied to the exact spot they happened spark interest.

PRIVACY & APPROACHABILITY

“This feels like I’m more just nonchalant... [the other one] is... a little scary.”
— Participant

→ A small, book-like form feels lower-pressure than a large pod.

LEAVING SOMETHING BEHIND

“I like the aspect of leaving something to the next person.”
— Participant

→ Leaving a trace for a future visitor is part of the appeal.

What we learned and what changed

FINDING

Some participants relied on subtitles to follow video.

↓ DESIGN RESPONSE

Multilingual subtitles

Read along with video and spoken stories — in more than one language.

FINDING

Team reading: comprehension needs can be about language, not just format.

↓ DESIGN RESPONSE

Language selection

Switch the interface language to lower barriers for international students.

FINDING

Participants preferred short, quick interactions.

↓ DESIGN RESPONSE

Reel Mode

Scroll through short stories continuously — a casual way to browse in downtime.

Built in prototype code · not yet tested long-term

FINDING

Participants differed on reading, listening and watching.

↓ DESIGN RESPONSE

Guided mode + format choice

Category → subcategory → video, audio or text → View more or I'm done → leave something behind.

FINDING

Participants valued leaving something for the next person.

↓ DESIGN RESPONSE

Comments & responses

React to a story and add your own thoughts for whoever comes next.

